

Look Sharp

While shopping for electronic gizmos there is always a chance that you might get conned while buying a certain product, or that the shopkeeper may get a little apprehensive giving out information as most of these products are either smuggled or attract high import duties. It is therefore advisable to check out various shops and locations other than regular shopping zones so as to get a better idea of the products and prices available. While the dealers seem more than ready to sell their wares, a bit of probing about the products gets them a little jumpy at times. Normally at these places you have to pay in cash as credit cards are usually not accepted. A closer examination of the product is usually greeted with shifty eyes and words such as "trust us, we only deliver the genuine and best quality items". As far as after sales service is concerned, you might be able to get some alterations in the servicing and technical help contracts, but never expect your product to be fully exchanged or replaced.

Shopping Checklist

Look out for these while shopping for electronic items

- ✓ Do your research thoroughly and check the genuineness of the product
- ✓ Insist on a warranty card
- ✓ Read the clauses in the agreement
- ✓ Demand after sales service
- ✓ Ask a couple of people before buying a certain product
- ✓ Check the authenticity of the product and the distributor/retail store/outlet

WMA formats", says Suhasini Ahluwalia, Marketing Director at O'Reilly & Associates.

Do you really need to have the latest, most expensive model, or is there another deal available that works well for you? Once you have figured out what you want in your MP3 player (for instance), you can then make a shortlist of the models that offer these features and then try and get closer look.

Try it before you buy it

Those of you who have actually gone out and tried to buy one of these devices could probably vouch for the fact that this can be quite an experience. Obviously, before spending the pretty packet that many of these cost, you'd like to make sure that you have the best deal available. For that you'd have to find a reliable store with the latest stock.

For instance, if you're looking for a digital camera that allows you to shoot all the photographs you need and store them on your PC or a CD-ROM drive, then the first place you should look is probably one of the many PC retail stores. Many of these stores display entry-level digital cameras and Web-cams offered by brands such as Logitech and Intel. There are a few up and coming stores that offer a wider selection of brands, but these are few and far between. Agrani Convergence Ltd has recently launched a couple of Switch stores in Delhi and Bangalore, which aim to become a one-stop shop for technology products and services.

However, if you are really particular about the brand or model that you want, you could probably follow the example of Steven D'Souza, a hi-tech gadget enthusiast, who decided that he simply had to get his hands on a digital camera and decided on a Sony Mavica MVC-FD 73. "I finally managed to buy it at a huge electronics market in Saudi Arabia," says D'Souza. Most of you who know specifically what you want will find that the best solution is probably to pick up the gadget yourself during a trip abroad, or just ask a friend do it for you. "I am thrilled with the performance of my camera and am convinced that I made a good choice," quips D'Souza.



"I saw the Rio Volt MP3 player on Cnet.com in a review of the top five MP3 players and was bowled over by its cool features"

Suhasini Ahluwalia

Marketing Director, O'Reilly & Associates

Taking the plunge

Once you have decided on a particular model, you need to keep certain things in mind. One of the first things you should consider is price. While it might seem a lot cheaper to buy an iPaq handheld from the US, there are a few things that you need to be careful about. The warranty in most cases would probably not be applicable in India, which means that the product should come with an international warranty, which will ensure that you could get it serviced in India. Always a matter of concern, however, is the avail-



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ability of spares. Getting a replacement part for newer models can take some time and spares for older models can also be difficult to obtain. People who bought laptops a few years ago will be familiar with this situation. However, the situation will improve over time as more of these products become available in India.

Another option that you have is to place an order with a company or stores based in the US. You can make a selection on a Web-based store and have the product shipped over to India. The product is sent over via a courier service and you could pretty much have it delivered to your doorstep, though shipping charges will be extra. Compusa.com, Circuitcity.com, Computershopper.com and Egghead.com are a few sites that allow you to do this easily. Of course, you need to have an international credit card to make use of these